

Before documenting the project plan, each of them volunteered to conduct pilot research to get an idea of the public's response to their concept. All six stood outside libraries and prominent bookstores for hours, trying to get feedback from the book-reading public.

They covered major cities such as Delhi, Mumbai, Bangalore, Kolkata, and Hyderabad. They considered factors like readership, customer reach, availability of infrastructure, and others during the research, analysis and discussion. Finally, they decided to start off from Mumbai, since they believed this was where the readership could be best explored.

Operation

When you come up with the idea for a project like this one, there's a clear route to be followed—after looking back upon the feasibility of the idea.

First, you need to pursue functions such as identifying channel resources, the area of operation, and the target audience. The Librarywala team got in touch with all major book publishers and distribution channels to source the books for their library.

Then comes the site itself—how it will work. What you need to think about how to develop it, test it and fix bugs, enable certified and secure e-commerce features, use CRM (Customer Relations Management) software, secure the back-end IT infrastructure—and you even need to think about such things as taking backups of the database.

Next, you approach Web site developers and discuss requirements. In the case of Librarywala, three final-year students from a software programming and IT course—Rajesh Jain, Nilesh Jadhav, and Shruti Rao—designed and developed Librarywala.com.

The Web site was developed on the .NET 2.0 framework using ASP.NET 2.0, C#, SQL Server, and AJAX. "The initial programming and development of the Web site consumed a lot of time and energy—both ours as well as the programmers'. The entire development and beta-testing of Web site took about eight months—longer than we'd expected," informs Turakhia.

Next comes the core e-commerce aspect: if you're an online business, you'll need services from payment gateway providers and partners such as banks or PaisaPay, which helps you pay through credit card without revealing the number. You then make an application for a Secured Socket Layer certification from a leading SSL Certificate Authority such as VeriSign. In this case, the payment gateway on the site for credit and debit cards employs SSL-based 128-bit VeriSign-certified encryption. Customers' details are stored with the payment gateway.

Now that you've got customers, CRM software is to be used to keep track of what's happening on the site. This can be customised.

Finally, you need to see how you're doing: this means regular reports. At Librarywala, Crystal Reports Server has been installed for daily reports of user registrations, members' book queue lists,



We've used the best available technologies for our site and look forward to imbibe more of it in the future scope of our operations"

Hiten Dedhiya
Director
Librarywala.com



Imagine browsing these shelves without having to haul yourselves out of your chair!

and such. These regularly reach at the servers at the main office. The security of the back-end IT infrastructure needs to be taken care of, too.

Using the reports, the team tracks user preferences: which genres top the priority lists, and so on. There is also a referral system in place, à la Amazon: those who read a Jeffery Archer novel might like a John Grisham thriller, for example.

Regular backups of the site content and database takes place in the US, where the Web site is hosted.

Expansion

In terms of operations, the top priority for the Librarywala team is, of course, to expand their services to more cities. In addition, in order to reach a larger audience, Turakhia mentioned to use their plans to implement a WAP-based service on their Web site; he believes the mobile phone is the next-best source of customers—everyone has one.

If and when proper Global Positioning System services become available, the delivery boys could use GPS devices or GPS-enabled cell phones. The team believes they can save a lot of time in terms of pick-ups and deliveries in one area.

On the cards are services like blogs and forums, where members can interact and share book reviews. There are plenty of precedents that can be looked at here.

Motivation

Turakhia avers, "Technology is a great enabler. It can be leveraged to create sound business models in education, animation, design, and advertising, to name a few."

So what could be next for rentals online? Think about video game discs, since games are notoriously expensive in India—actually, the rates themselves are low, but we're talking about the lure of pirated copies and also about purchasing power. Then, think about rentals of laptops and projectors by small organisations that only need them for a short while. What about cameras? Some people just need a high-end camera for one trip! What about men's formal suits to be used at weddings? Saris? Dresses for Navratri? Expensive-looking fake jewellery? Speakers and amplifiers for festive occasions?

Some of these do exist offline, but the point of the Internet is two-fold: that of affording the luxury of not having to get out of home, and that of providing the facility to browse extensively, compare objectively, and so on. This holds even for Librarywala and BookSwim.

From auctions to selling and now renting online, the Internet has created markets where none existed. Business enterprises also reduce costs on inventory.

In all the above—right from the outset—what stands out most is a facet of human nature: the need for comfort. People very often just don't want to get outdoors. They'd like to be in the comfort of their homes. They enjoy the power of the mouse-click. In fact, impulsive mouse clicks result in spending that just wouldn't have been done offline. Think about it. ☐

samir_makwana@thinkdigit.com